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(अ. भा. सर्वोदय मण्डल)
महादेवभाई भवन,
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GANDHIAN WAY and THE BHOODAN MOVEMENT

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CHAPTER I

RAMRAJ : GANDHIAN DEMOCRACY

Democracy has been variously defined by political thinkers and constitutionalists. Right from Abraham Lincoln's lofty dictum 'Government of the People, by the People and for the People' down to Sir John Seely's rather narrower description as 'Government in which everyone has a share' Democracy has assumed nothing more than a political significance and meaning. In fact, almost on all hands the political aspect of the expression has been given as much regard as have been disregarded its socio-economic and cultural aspects.

Although a finer and fuller expression than what has been used by Lincoln, the revered Liberator of mankind, can hardly be conceived of, Lincoln's followers and the future Democrats all over the world sharply narrowed down its scope and vied in the political field alone. To-day, generally speaking, Democracy means nothing more than a system in which political power rests with the body of elected representatives of the people as opposed to the rule of the one 'superman' or of an oligarchy of the 'superior' few.

Western Democracies

The French and Czarist Russian revolutions brought in their wake a large-scale awakening among the masses, particularly among the peasantry and factory workers. Unlike the medieval priestly rule and exclusive political rights of the landlords and a section of upper middle class the flow of political consciousness now took a reverse course and rapidly descended to the poorer sections or have-nots of the Society. This lower level people were now imbued with the feeling that they had some inalienable rights in the Government of the country; once these rights were established, or in other words, the powers of administration were seized, there would be an end of their miseries. Meanwhile the Western Nations, particularly Great Britain and U. S. A. the forerunners of modern Democracies were making rapid strides in large-scale industrialization and unlike the earlier periods of their history, factory centres, as against small village units, turned into cities and the 'centres of gravity'. National resources, both of men and materials, were allowed to drain out and be heavily dumped in these modern places of awakened political interests. The strides of centralized production in the West have also vitally affected the western political thoughts and ideas. These new dumping grounds were generally formed into constituencies and the struggling

masses were now armed with certain political rights, the foremost of which was the right to vote. Thus the central ideal of modern democracies, at least theoretically, is the political power or the power to vote, and the widest possible degree of personal freedom.

Individual and State

World-wide miseries of the masses have brought to the fore the illusory nature of this political power or the power to vote. From the voting right the citizens no doubt derive a sense of political effectiveness, but in practical politics, again the power of a particular group of shrewd intellectuals becomes uppermost and vocal, and the inalienable rights and privileges of the ordinary voting citizens recede to the background. Democracy being a mere political democracy, there is almost no scope for the development of the personality and conscience of the voter which alone can be the basis of his effective strength. With the signing of the ballot paper, even this mere political privilege is surrendered to a small intellectual group within the party and in the name of the State this group stands supreme in subjugation of the people at large. This again inevitably and drastically curtails the freedom of the individual. Freedom of expression and freedom of movement is there no doubt, but the freedom of conscience is submerged in total darkness.

Starit-jacketed, the fountains of the individual spirit are woefully sealed up. There is no denying the fact that even in countries most vocal in their adherence to democratic ideals, there is an ever-increasing trend towards the infringement of the rights of the individual and the enthronement of the State at his expense. Truly, it has been said that 'the price of the planned State is the freedom of the individual.' Life is for living with a purpose, and fruitfully. A true democracy can ill afford to ignore creation of environments in which individual life can achieve a natural and full efflorescence. Have the modern democracies demonstrated their adherence, in practice, to this human purpose? Invariably not.

Decentralized Administration

It is high time we realised that the technological revolution, unless followed by a decentralized system of economy and administration is bound to be fruitless and baffling. It is nothing short of sabotaging politics to give the freedom of vote to the individual by one hand and deprive him of his life-blood by the other; to invest a group of intellectuals with supreme powers and to let the people lose heavily in material and moral spheres. Political democracy putting up with economic and ethical slavery of the masses is a self-condemned arrangement. Rather, it is the economic democracy

and moral development of the individual which makes political democracy dynamic and fruitful. And this is the ideal which Mahatma Gandhi in his memorable expression called 'Swaraj' or 'Ramraj'. Says he :

"By political independence I do not mean an imitation of the British House of Commons, or the Soviet Rule of Russia or the Fascist rule of Italy or the Nazi rule of Germany. They have systems suited to their genius. We must have ours suited to ours. What that can be is more than I can tell. I have described it as 'Ramraj' i. e. sovereignty of the people based on pure moral authority."

Again,

"According to me the constitution of India and for the matter of that of the world, should be such that no one under it should suffer from want of food and clothing. In other words everybody should be able to get sufficient work to enable him to make the two ends meet. And this ideal can be universally realized only if 'the means of production of the elementary necessities of life remain in the control of the masses.' These should be freely available to all as God's air and water are or ought to be; they should not be made a vehicle of traffic for the exploitation of others. Their monopolization by any country, nation or group of persons,

would be unjust. The neglect of this simple principle is the cause of the destitution that we witness today not only in this unhappy land but in other parts of the world too."

So, in political set-up 'sovereignty of the people based on pure moral authority' and in economic administration 'production of the elementary necessities of life remain in the control of the masses' constitute the fundamental principles in a Gandhian Democracy. And that decentralization of political and economic power of the country is the only means to achieve this end can hardly be disputed. To build up a society that affords full scope for the development of the individual and yet establish a relative equality by helping and safeguarding the interest of the weak and thus forming a brotherhood in which one cannot exploit the other is to represent the eternal principles of human civilization and progress. Nothing else than a decentralized pattern of democracy, which alone can be styled a democracy, in the truest sense of the term, can found the whole life of the people on moral authority and co-operative commonwealth. To quote some famous lines of Sri J C. Kumarappa, "we may create functional democrats overnight, but cultural democracies are products of millennia. Only the latter will stand the test of time."

Ancient Indian Republics

Decentralization was the great principle that worked at the root of socio-economic and political life of Ancient India. 'Nitisastras' 'Puras', 'Kautilya's Arthasastra' and similar other scriptures and holy books unmistakably point to this historical fact. Unlike the modern city-centered administration, village was the administrative unit in those times. Village Republics functioned as 'free, autonomous and independent' organisations, and controlled the vital affairs of the community. Historians suggest that it was Lord Buddha who introduced the term 'Republic' in general administration. And we know, it was Buddha who founded the Republic of the Bhikkus (Monks). This goes to show that the introduction of 'Republics' in administrative affairs had a religious fervour behind it. One foreign conquerer after another has swept over India, but the village municipalities have stuck to the soil. Since the Gupta period of Indian History, the functions of Government have been increasingly complex and centralized, and by 1900, the 'shining' stage of British Rule in India, the resources of the country and power of the countrymen have smuggled out to a handful of cities in the hands of a group of persons. R. C. Dutt, the famous Historian notably remarks, "One of the saddest results of British Rule in India is

the effacement of the system of village Self-Government which was developed earliest and preserved longest in India amongst all the countries of the earth".

Among the functions of these village Republics or 'Panchayets' we find that "they were absolute proprietors of lands and possessed rights of ownership over all newly cleared lands. They imposed and collected taxes and could, if they chose, declare a village tax-free. They were also authorised to take possession of and to sell the land of peasants who had failed to pay them taxes over a period of three years. They were responsible for the administration of local justice, and adjudicated upon all crimes from petty theft to murder.

Torch-bearer of Indian culture and heritage as he is, Gandhiji depicts a picture of village Swaraj thus :—

"My idea of village Swaraj is that it is a complete republic, independent of its neighbours for its vital wants, and yet interdependent for many others in which dependence is a necessity. Thus every village's first concern will be to grow its own food crops and cotton for its cloth. It should have a reserve for its cattle, recreation and play-grounds for adults and children . . ."

Mechanical Democracies

Modern democracies, with a thoroughly mechanical background, are a far cry from the villages and village culture. Sacred individuality is being trampled under their technological devices. The individual and Society are basic—while the State is but an offshoot; the tragedy of modern thinking is that in the name of States dynamism the individual has been turned into static, soulless, mechanical instrument. A direct consequence of centralization as it is, a decentralized system of administration alone can save humanity from this decadence. The wider the administrative set-up, the closer is the contact of the administration with the people. And this super-structure cannot be built up unless the foundation is based upon village unit i.e. the bottom layer of the State. An effective local administration on this pattern, linked up with the higher bodies, would at once make the masses well-governed and devolve upon them the responsibility of government too. The central theme of the whole approach can be summed up in that famous dictum 'the least governed is the best governed.' We have noted at the outset that the revolutionary industrial changes have had their stamps left on the political ideas and approaches too. It is sheer non-sense to highlight the principle of democracy in full-throated declaration,

and along side, allow the exploitation of the masses, in a pernicious system of economy. There can be no political equality with so much economic inequality. Machines have not only, 'revolutionized' the means of production, they have polluted beyond recognition the nature of politics too, so that the general effect of modern democracies have been unfavourable to the freedom of the individual. Reasonable men have been turned into will-less mechanical slaves,—and does it not defeat the very purpose of a Democratic State. Under the so-called democracies machine civilization is forging ahead and human culture is limping behind. Lacking in moral authority, the Frankenstein of mechanical rule cannot but consume its creator. Let us beware. ●

CHAPTER II

GANDHIJI & DECENTRALIZATION

Gandhiji's ceaseless quest for Swaraj or a society based on Truth is characterised by strict adherence to decentralised economic order. In fact, decentralization holds almost a pivotal position in the Gandhian way of development. When centralisation is being regarded as the symbol of civilisation and the only efficient means of production and rabid race for Mammon worship is high-lighting this 'march of civilisation', Gandhiji by his idea of decentralization, which signifies simple living free from exploitation and based on co-operation as against modern complicated living, was very much ridiculed and given the title of a retrograde thinker, an opponent of the forces of progress—so on and so forth. With his prophetic vision, however, Gandhiji could foresee the disaster that would inevitably overtake the modern civilisation with its mad race for speed and power. He was for peace and therefore for decentralized way of life altogether ruling out competition, concentration of wealth and power which constitute the forces of war.

Village Industries

Village industries from the foundation of a de-

centralized economy as envisaged by Gandhiji, we know that the advent of Gandhiji in the public life of India was through economics. The poverty of the Indian masses shocked him profoundly and it was his conviction that he could not carry God to the poor except in the shape of a bowl of rice. His historic campaigns at Champaran, Bardoli and other places were for economic causes and even in 1930 he selected the poor man's salt for 'Satyagraha'. His deep appreciation and anxiety for indigenous industries is reflected in the saying that 'what the Gita says with regard to Swadharma equally applies to Swadeshi.'

Gandhiji was the great architect of India's awakening and this miracle he performed through the shielding of Swadeshi spirit. He knew no rest and had no peace until the two organizations, the All-India Spinners Association and the All India Village Industries Association, came into being and piloted his scheme for Khadi and village industries respectively. It was again at his instance and bountiful inspiration that "Khadi" and "Gram-udyog" exhibitions began to high-light congress Sessions since 1934. Many will remember his eloquent appeal to the visitors of the Lucknow Exhibition, the first of its kind, to patronise rural handicraft and industries. Whenever Gandhiji spoke on rural problems the soul of the country would stir.

A Friend of Mankind

Gandhiji was not merely a friend of the poor—he was a lover of mankind and so a votary of peace. His conception of decentralized economy should therefore, be read in the background of world peace. Of the two ruling economic systems, Capitalism which received a great fillip from the Industrial Revolution is evidently on its last legs now. This decay or derangement is primarily due to the loss of colonial rule which once guaranteed easy exploitation of raw materials to the Capitalist—Imperialist powers. Nobody would champion the cause of Capitalism in the sense that a few should thrive on the toils and turmoils of many. Capitalist economy being itself an organised violence can never serve the cause of peace.

Similarly the Communist economy, the other form of economic organisation in the world, also stands self-contradicted and has, to all intents and purposes, run contrary to true Communism. Its extreme insistence on concentration of power is a menace to equalitarian society. Unlike Capitalism that concentrates wealth, Communism has concentrated totalitarian power in the hands of a few. But there is a close affinity between the two : both are staunch believers in centralized production and survive on the same instinct, i.e. the instinct of increasing possession or material hunger, raising the

bogey of 'high standard of living'. Hence we see that they are not as different in spirit as in form.

Here, then comes decentralized economy which, while assuring a reasonable standard of living for all, makes democracy what it is worth. As Gandhiji said, a truly democratic nation is that which runs its affairs smoothly. And control of primary production by the people is the pre-requisite for such smooth Government. Let not the economic life of the Nation be closed in the fist of a few—as in Capitalism, nor regimented as in Communism. All primary needs and needs for all consumer goods shall be satisfied through village industries, so that production becomes natural and thus gets a solid and broad foundation while ensuring better distribution, better nutrition and more employment.

Gandhiji & Revolution

Gandhiji's abhorrence of bloody revolution and violent expropriation is also well-known. Gandhism seeks to eliminate exploitation at the very root i.e. at the production stage and decentralization alone can fulfil this object and so arrange our economic affairs as to avoid untruth and violence. "These villages cannot retain the freedom they have enjoyed from time immemorial, if they do not control the prime necessities of life"—said Gandhiji. Swadeshism to him was a doctrine of selfless service to the people. "Any article

is Swadeshi if it subserves the interest of millions, even though the capital and talent are foreign but under effective Indian control"—this clearly shows his mind.

The idea was much enlarged when he sought to organize the village industries on co-operative basis within the frame-work of self-sufficient local economy. Key industries should according to him be the States' concern or managed by public corporation, and this is quite a rational approach striking balance and bringing about equilibrium between the two sectors of industries without prejudicing the high national culture and tradition. So decentralized production should not be viewed from the standpoint of giving out 'doles' to industries in distress but should be treated as a vital National question concerning both physical and mental regeneration of Free India.

सर्व सेवा मंत्र पुस्तकालय

सेवाग्राम, बंधो.

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CHAPTER III

SOCIAL CONTROL OF LAND

Introduction in the W. B. State Assembly of a Zemindary Abolition Bill marks the beginning of a major move towards land re-settlement and resultant revolution in agricultural production. 'Land to the tiller' formerly recognised as an oft-repeated political slogan has now been found to be an expedient measure with the passing of times. This is as it should be. More so in a country like India which has its power of sustenance and growth inherent in agricultural economy. Incidentally it occurs to us that the very full-throat proverbial saying of Gokhale that 'What Bengal thinks today India thinks tomorrow' has been reversed in the case of land reforms, may be for the presentation of a flawless and more workable scheme of reforms.

Today there is perhaps none but admit the justice and judiciousness in giving land to the tiller by abolishing all intermediary interests. This will at once restore the vital link between the Government and its most useful and paying source, and revitalise the owning peasantry with a sense of robust optimism. This again,

we believe, will let loose a fresh current of co-operation and goodwill to the benefit of the rest, i.e. the non-possessing peasantry or the agricultural labour. This entire scheme, however, presupposes the fixation of the optimum size of holdings.

But restoring the peasantry to its rightful and legitimate ownership is not an end in itself. We may say this is the beginning of the end. Apart from the question of bountiful State help and organization of co-operative farming, enforcement of suitable social or community control over all lands of a village or a group of villages is a very powerful factor in rendering the whole course of possession and production fully adhesive and coherent, and conducive to the co-operative commonwealth of village India. By this Community Control we mean the Village Panchayat or Mandal, which, while being a voluntary organization constituted mostly by the peasants (in almost any village the largest single group is the peasantry) will at the same time impose upon itself the social responsibilities supported by necessary legal provisions. This is no novel idea. But more on this point later.

Here it is only meet and proper that we defend our case for private ownership with overall social control as against rigorous and regimented State-ownership of land. The prevalent idea among one section that small-scale farming is always uneconomic and large-scale

farming, i.e., collective farming under State ownership, guidance and aid is the only economic alternative does not always hold true. Rather unless the pleasure of possession is restored to and retained by the tiller one retrograde step will have been taken psychologically and the "creative genius of the cultivator seriously handicapped under the wheels. India, China and Japan on the one hand and U. S. A., U. S. S. R. and many other countries of Europe stand poles asunder, taking into consideration the difference in their local conditions and needs. Unlike the former, the latter have scarcity of labour with extensive land. In the U. S. A. with an agricultural population of 18% of the total, there is an increasing tendency towards small-scale farming because a large number of people desire to settle on land. Even in the U. S. S. R. which is the home of collective farms, the State has allotted one acre of homestead lot to every farmer for his own cultivation. *Russian farmers take more personal interest in this one acre plot than in the collective farms* (Sri S. N. Agarwal in *Congress Sandesh* d. 12-5-52). It requires no far-stretched imagination or foresight to predict in India, the land of agriculture, this pleasure of personal possession will be hundred times more pronounced. And the problem of full employment in agriculture also forms another basic consideration. Machine-led and power-driven collective farms will have a natural

tendency towards 'rationalisation' which is the other name of unemployment today ! So State-controlled land system and land management will not only not improve the employment situation, it will, actually also cripple the national genius of the peasantry. So the argument that we must undo the evils of fragmented holdings by State Collective Farms hits itself back except to the extent of fixing up the optimum size of holdings. Japan with an average of holding of 2.5 acres produces three times as much per acre in India, and the cultivation is mostly done by hand, nor by tractors or horses or bullocks. Model State farms or demonstration centres are, however, everywhere welcome.

Back to the point of Community Control. As we have stated, this is no novel idea. That 'the right of cultivation will belong to the cultivator, but he must be subject to the control of the community' is a very healthy legacy brought forward from not-too-distant Indian history. Says Kautilya in his Artha Shastra, "Non-cultivation of land by the peasant or his letting it out to a third person renders it liable to confiscation." Another unimpeachable non-Indian authority says, "They (the English management of India) transformed to the utmost of their ability the Indian commune with common ownership of the soil into a caricature of itself." Besides the periodical ravages wrought by

flood, famine or pestilence leading to rapid and large-scale transfer of lands from peasant hands, absence of any community control over this social asset has also helped in no small measure this process of disintegration. In Bombay the 'per capita' land owned by the cultivating class is 10 acres as against 15.9 acres owned by the non-cultivating class. Most other States also tell the same tale. And there are reasons to believe that in Bengal the owning cultivator's proportion is precariously low. Only a democratic, self-imposed community control on all lands currently with suitable State programmes can stop this rust. Post-war position has made some spectacular strides in the sphere of agriculture, of which the Agricultural Act of 1947 eminently deserves our notice and emulation in at least some respects. Section 9 of the Act lays down the strict directive on the farmers to follow the rules of good estate management, and the penalty provided under Section 16 or non-compliance is the dispossession of owners or occupiers. It can be expected that Village Panchayats in India fully equipped with autonomous powers should have a better scope and prospect of success in land control. It was rightly observed by the Congress Agrarian Reforms Committee (1949) presided over by Sri J. C. Kumarappa that, "As the village community is ultimately a group in which the

majority are cultivators, the rights vesting in the village community in a way are the rights which the peasants would enjoy in their group personality and the control to be exercised by the village community would be a self-imposed control. Under such a democratic control his incentive to production would be canalised and not crippled." Thus peasant proprietorship with maximum possession of one single individual station fixed up is not incompatible with good husbandry, provided of course the afore-stated community control is enforced and principles of co-operative farming within the framework of the proposed community organization are assiduously put to practice. Happily, the first Planning Commission of India has laid the desired stress on both community organisation and co-operative farming. It is now for the Government to speedily act up to these recommendations.

CHAPTER IV

GREAT POSSIBILITIES OF GRAMDAN & SARVODAYA

In India's Second Five-Year Plan the following observations have been made on Gramdan or whole village donations in the Bhoodan Movement : "The practical success which is achieved in the development of Gramdan in Orissa and elsewhere villages will have great significance for co-operative village development elsewhere in the country". Earlier, in defining the roles of individual and co-operative sectors in land management, the Planning Commission has also emphasized that the "aim would be to enlarge the co-operative sector until management of the entire land in the village becomes the co-operative responsibility of the community."

It is gratifying that the Planning Commission, the highest authority to advise and guide the Government in their "Socialistic Pattern" ideal has not failed to take note of the immense possibilities of Gramdan. The striking difference in the approaches by the Government and by Vinoba to the land problem is, however, obvious. While the Government's treatment of the

malady is mainly legislative, the Bhoodan treatment is mainly and essentially psychological. For Parliamentary Democracy—whatever be its home traditions and characteristics—legislation cannot but be the mainstay ; and legislations, even by the shrewdest of legal brains are apt to contain loopholes. That through such loopholes many big landholders in the States have wriggled out is an open secret. So legislation itself is no remedy, far less a solvent of discords or disparities unless geared by a suitable psychological background.

Benefit To Last Man

Secondly, if by Socialistic Pattern we seriously mean anything, we must mean an order of society built from below, from the bottom which unquestionably is the village unit. But even simple adoption of the village as the base is not enough, it has also to be seen that the benefits of socialistic planning do reach the last man, rather reach the last man in the society first. And once it is done, that is, the development of the last man is assured, logically the outcome of the work will inform the whole structure thus bringing about which is called Sarvodaya or Universal Development. Gramdan as we will presently see, apart from stimulating right-thinking about ownership of land, has opened up the flood-gate of this 'welfare of all' or Sarvodaya as distinguished from the greatest good of the greatest

number which is the sheet-anchor of modern democracies.

Whatever the differences on the surface, multiplication of wants and material possessions is the propelling force in practically each and every form of State organisation today. The primary consideration or the all important desideratum is the 'matter' and not the 'man'. The 'whole man' has been divided into so many water-tight compartments, and the approach is to the 'parts' and 'parties' instead of to the 'whole' or to universal welfare.

Gandhiji's Approach

Soon after his advent in Indian freedom struggle Gandhiji warned us about this wrong approach and also pointed out the fundamental difference as between 'standard of living' and 'standard of life'. In the name of efficiency which indeed is a camouflage for unfettered competition and flagrant profiteering economy in total disregard of service to the neighbours or society, wanton injustice to or even extinction of the weaker wing is sought to be justified. Extinction of India's traditional industries in the face of competition by the so-called efficient urban industries is an example in point. Gandhiji gave us outlines of planning which while maintaining the traditions of Indian village civilization could also successfully co-exist with a progressive economy in the true sense. He conceived

of self-sufficient rural communities with decentralization as the hall-mark of the national economy and administration, not for isolation of Indian villages from her towns or cities or isolation of the country from other countries, but to provide India with a strong footboard in these fast-moving times.

A country consisting of over five-hundred-thousand villages and with a rural population of over 80% of the total must necessarily have the village as the basic political and economic unit, with a primary voice in the National Plan. Be it in the management and use of land or choice of crops or utilisation and export of raw materials produced in the village, this basic unit has got to be the springboard for overall planning. And such a process from the deep bottom will do away with the unhealthy functions of the middlemen or 'intermediary interest' in cultivation, handling of raw materials etc. and axe at the root of exploitation too. An iron-handed, power-intoxicated administrator can perhaps root out the millionaires ; but such forcible dispossession inevitably lets loose a cycle of permanent rivalry and bid for the armed might of the State, bringing in its trail ceaseless fear, misery and spiritual dwarfing of the masses. Personal liberty or expression of the personality in man—which is the real measure of democracy in a State—is circumscribed, in such

cases, by some extraneous considerations. The arms way is therefore, not the right way, inasmuch as, it brings in more problems than it solves.

A Total Revolutionary

Revolution is the outcome of great ideas, and great ideas are born in individuals. It is fantastic to visualise that one who is unwilling to revolutionize his own life can bring about revolution or inspire confidence for revolution. And revolution in one's life and ways means in the true sense, sacrifices in increasing doses and ultimately becoming 'zero' and absolutely free from attachment. It is at this 'zero' hour when one sees in everything 'thine' and not 'mine' and becomes a total revolutionary. So it is not in the forcible dispossession of the millionaires but in the voluntary sacrifices by the millions where lies revolution. Once millions and millions of the masses understand this basic principles of life and rise above personal gain and attachment to material property which to them also is no less strong than in the case of millionaires—a superb revolutionary atmosphere sets in which even the most die-hard or unchangeable of the vested interests will be only too powerless to ignore. If, for argument's sake, he refuses to live by mutual sharing, seeks to stick to his exclusiveness even under such circumstances, he can hardly pull on very long in so

far as the outside world is concerned and even his neighbours will be unresponsive to him and he will soon find himself in a solitary cell where even tons of material property will taste deadly sour.

Lot of the Tillers

We have pointed out the pivotal role that a village must play in socialistic planning for India. Socialist or Socialistic Pattern is understood more easily in economic terms than otherwise. Land is the mainstay and means of living of as many as 7 out of every 10 Indians. So, land is the source of our strength. Unfortunately, so far land has reversely been the source of our weakness. Real tillers of the soil very largely remained unfed and unclothed under an alien rule. And this rendered the inside defence of the Nation extremely shaky and poor. Not only was a non-producing class of landlords created and pampered to the detriment of the society and real producers deprived of their rightful share of the produce, but production too was planned in a manner inimical to the interest of the villagers. It is common knowledge how a policy of producing cash crops even in areas frequented by famine and drainage of both foodcrop and raw materials of village industries out of the village in subservience to overseas factory interests was followed zealously. Such a policy led to the diminution of production and

degenerated the millions living in rural India in particular.

Voluntary Sharing

There is no denying that even today villagers themselves have little control, if at all, on crop planning or utilization of raw materials. Gramdan, has, therefore, unleashed a hitherto unknown revolutionary concept of socio-economic pattern, where land is owned by the community and used in pursuance of an extended family principle, namely, from each according to his capacity to each according to his needs. The policy of production of crops and utilization of raw materials is so framed that the unexplored national energy is harnessed to ensure equitable distribution of the national dividend and progressive elimination of income inequalities. And this alone can inject in even the last and most backward man in the society the glow of freedom. On the progress of gramdan, i. e. the surrender of exclusive self-interest to social ownership and enjoyment, or voluntary sharing between all member-families of the village will depend much of our socialistic achievements, both in agricultural and industrial sectors.

The Latent Spirit

In an age of deep attachment to private property, proprietary rights of land of over 1300 whole villages

have been surrendered, in course of a few years, as a result of sweet persuasion and appeal to the innate good sense of man. It is no argument that at this rate it will take scores of years to bring the whole land of the country within the Bhoodan or Sarvodaya framework of redistribution. Revolution is essentially an inward process: it works first deep inside. Time itself is no major factor, by no means the decisive factor. It is the 'spirit' latent in man which can, by its enlightenment and awakening, shorten the period of transition, annihilate the distance and bring the goal nearer and nearer.

CHAPTER V

A MOVEMENT THAT STIRS THE INDIAN COUNTRYSIDE

The Bhoodan Movement acknowledged as unique in many respects has been stirring India, especially India's countryside for over 12 years. The same uniqueness characterizes the man, saint Vinoba Bhave, who has been the spearhead of this 'land-gifts mission' since April 18, 1951 on which day Bhoodan blossomed in a South Indian village.

Bhoodan has since made remarkable strides—Gramdan (whole-village donations), Shanti Sena (Peace Brigade), Sarvodaya Patra (an earthen pot which is preserved in a household and a handful of corn or a *naya paysa* is poured into it as a mark of the householder's identification with the values that Bhoodan represents.)

Now what are those values? Are these compatible with or acceptable in an age of scientific marvels?

Before going into the details of the Bhoodan programmes and how they affect or impress our present social structure it should be noted that it is precisely because of the amazing progress of science that Bhoodan, studied in the correct perspective, commends itself as

the greatest solvent for the ills and evils that threaten to paralyse human civilization today, denuded of the right kind of values which alone can sustain a society. The human heart, is reduced to small and cold and divided shells of self-interest and increasing attachment this becoming incapable of containing a great world, a universe where all men are brothers. Bhoodan is a heroic, all comprehensive effort to resuscitate man to *truth, love and compassion* that comprise the sustaining values for civilization.

To a superficial observer "Vinoba Bhave is a strange paradox, in as much as a saint has undertaken an unusual adventure and is 'dabbling in all problems of the day instead of keeping himself completely immersed in 'Sadhana' or 'Seclusion' by shutting out from the noisy world. While some Westerners have characterized Vinobaji as the last of the saints, whose wisdom has characterized Indian life through the ages, 'the Bhoodan leaders' is, in fact, the first saint of the nuclear age, whose saintliness was not content with secluded interest and salvation of his ownself, but delved into the realm of science in order that the roots of an ideal society could grow from the much-heralded marriage of science and self-knowledge or spirituality. He is a saintly revolutionary who is seeking a synthesis of these two forces now which can be ideally harnessed to the cause of Sarvodaya

or Universal well-being all alone. India's history is replete with saintly characters, but despite them and their spiritual courses, the social fabric continued to degenerate due to an acrimonious living on widening dessensive inequalities discrimination. Either they did not consider it necessary to associate with the fellow-travellers and lead them, as a whole society, to light out of seething darkness or they could not evolve a suitable technique of social change. As a result, India has an accumulated filth of inequalities and injustices while there is no death of scattered greatness in her history. While the saint provided a beacon to individuals, the technique of social salvation was nobody's affair. And without a technique equal to the task, the opening flood gates of the achievements of science were virtually lost to the large body of men and women, that is the community. If anything characterizes the life of Vinoba Bhave and his Bhoodan Movement it is an ardent association of spiritual and scientific values, out of which is evolving a unique technique of social change, evident in Gramdan more than in any other aspect of the Movement. Founded, of course, on the positive tradition, tradition of spirituality, Bhoodan widened up the horizon for man's journey to a new world but not a world of Utopia. Mundane matters are no longer to be left to be the close preserve of self-seeking or closed minds, but such matters are

to derive their inspiration from spirituality or a realization of the oneness of all men, nay all world. If man has rolled in luxury in the midst of grinding poverty has killed fellow-men surrendering to his wild passions, if the achievement of science have been blatantly abused to the wanton detriment, to men, the reason is as we have pointed out at the outset, the growing division and intensifying ill-will that have set in. The spring-board of self-knowledge or spirituality was not utilized for providing an effective resistance to such disintegrate of the soul. The result has been most repugnant and disastrous. In a world glittering with man's conquest of space we witness the queer phenomenon, man's lamentable failure to win the hearts of fellow-men, failure to bring about a spiritual conquest. We have acquired the tremendous capacity to fly and venture to the moon land, but have not learnt or have unlearnt how to stand on good earth. With the passing away of Mahatma Gandhi, the mantle to explode this deriding contradiction and to establish and synthesise fell on Acharya Vinoba Bhave. A struggle between the forces of revolution or crystallization of the social dynamism and its progress from time to time, from age to age, and the die-hard, conservative practices of the existing machinery, however dedicated it may be, is the broad characteristic of a living society. At the vanguard of these revolutionary forces in India, which

shun the borrowed limelight and sacrifice the comfort, or careerist aspiration that normally drives a man in his life and activity, is a frail body, shedding an inexhaustible spiritual light, and that is Vinoba Bhave.

Who Is Vinoba ?

As the sponsor and leader of the Bhoodan Movement Vinobaji has captured the reverential attention of not only the millions in India, but also in most other countries of the world. About his antecedents one has only to take a retrospective look to that unique phase of our freedom movement. Under Gandhiji's leadership, when, in 1940, the Father of the Nation, proclaimed individual Satyagraha and setting aside the then stalwart, introduced Vinoba Bhave, to the Nation, as the first Satyagrahi. That Vinoba fully earned this unique honour and supreme trust and confidence of his Master was borne out by Gandhiji's assessment of him in the weekly "Harijan" of 20th October 1940. Gandhiji spoke eloquently on the sterling qualities of Vinoba and his unique accomplishments as an inmate of his Ashrama. It was, as if a Providential decree, that Vinobaji should again come out in the open and be called upon to frame and guide the destiny of India in a way that promises to be the only way for the world. Even today he may not strike the headlines of the Press, but one who has had

the thrilling experience of walking with him in his 'padayatra', and witnessing for himself how magnificently he evokes response from the hearts of villagers, how kindly and affectionately the millions of rural India in particular take him in course of his footmarch, can have no manner of doubt that a new leadership has already emerged where India will be found in its true character.

From Bhoodan to Gramdan

The exciting story of how Bhoodan made its advent would hardly bear repetition today. In course of his return walk from Sarvodaya Sammelan at Sivrapalli, Vinobaji arrived at Pochampalli a poor village—that is a village where the very large majority of the people did not have two meals a day in Telegana district. The Harijans, who proverbially belong to the lowest rung of the society, and tilled the lands of others for their living, took Vinoba as 'Bapu' (Gandhi) and prayed for some lands. Vinoba, whose only wealth was the loin cloth round his waist of course knew no answer to this question, the suddenness of which drowned in silence the meeting too. And then, just as a 'feeler' Vinoba said—was there none in the assembly who could give some lands to those fellows ?

"Yes, *Baba* (affectionate call to a spiritual teacher) I am ready to donate 100 acres for them". It was

highly incredible. Attachment to land is strong everywhere ; more so in India where land constitutes a basic and most permanent source of revenue. Dispute over titles to land leads to the breaking of heads even today, when the message of Bhoodan has created a climate favouring renunciation of private ownership of land and adoption of the way of shared living. The impact of the incident kept Vinoba awake throughout the night, and with the new morn the new vision of *Bhoodan Yajna* or a Mission for land-gifts, for land for the landless, induced Vinoba to set out for a walk, from village to village, that knows no rest knows no barriers, no hardship of summer, rains or winter. And the walk is still in progress, after over 12 years 3months, bringing in its wake nearly 42lakh acres of Bhoodan (individual land-gifts) and Gramdan (whole-village gifts). Of Bhoodan, over 10 lakh acres have been redistributed to 4 lakh landless families, which, in itself, is a unique achievement. This distribution is even quantitatively higher than that done by the State all over the country.

What Is Gramdan

Gramdan literally means 'dan' or donation of a 'Gram' or a village. Obviously a village is not a mobile property, how then can it possibly be donated? The fact of the matter is that private ownership of land is surrendered to communal or social ownership

which is represented by the Gram Sabha or Village Assembly. Originally the concept was villagization of all private lands in a village and vesting the entire ownership in the representative village body. But since that was too much that a society in the infancy of a collective thinking could bear, the rules were liberalised, so that today when no less than fifty-one percent of the lands and seventy-five percent of the villagers agree a village is considered eligible for Gramdan and a declaration is made accordingly at Vinobaji's next prayer meeting or otherwise. The redeeming features of Gramdan are that every land-owner signing the declaration shares as the beginning step, one-twentieth of his cultivable land with his landlessneighbours, and the rest of his ownership vests in the community although he continues to occupy and derive the benefit from such lands. By transfer of ownership to the village Assembly he surrenders his right to mortgage or sell the property, thus ensuring that the land of a village will under no circumstances, be purchasable by moneyed men of other villages or of the cities. This is an act of immediate revolution which is cutting across the evils of absentee landlordism and resultant fall in agricultural production. Furthermore, the owner also parts with a share of his produce annually and this forms the potential capital for the appropriate kind of industrialization in the village.

Again communal ownership of land potential renders the village fit for scientific farming operations on sizeable units. Economic and social consequences of Gramdan, i. e. voluntary villagization of land may, therefore, be summarized thus :

- (1) Landless gets land.
 - (2) Private ownership of all lands is surrendered to social ownership and control.
 - (3) Mortgage and sale of land is stopped.
 - (4) Farming operations on scientific lines made easier
- and
- (5) Private owner begins to realize the unjustness of owning what is truly a God-gift, and depriving his fellow-brothers.
 - (6) At the bottom layer of the country is built up an integrated society which is the first pre-requisite to democratic planning and its fruition on right lines.

This should be an adequate explanation why we have hailed Gramdan as a great technique of social change. And in a country like India a technique of social change, to be effective, must necessarily surround land and its ownership and management.

Incidentally, had the participating leaders of all major political parties adhered to their sacred declaration in favour of Gramdan made at Yelwal in Mysore

some eight years back and mobilised their goodwill and might for its actual progress, India could celebrate, that day, without doubt as a turning point in her history and planned development. But, alas, in no time the leaders again permitted themselves to be drained away in factional politics and acrimonious debates.

Vinobaji declared Gramdan as a ' Defence Measure ' long before India's border with China became a lusty object of aggression. Today he is reiterating this plea with greater emphasis in the context of the conflict and its inevitable impact which led to various emergency measures. But where is the sense of urgency, Vinobaji deplores, pointing out, in his characteristic outspokenness and simplicity, that when a sense of urgency pervades the life of a nation, no clamour for emergency is warranted. In fact, had we been urgent in dealing with the day-to-day problems of life, with matters that make or mar civic life, we would not have been called upon to summon so much additional and arbitrary power for security. Even the explosive propaganda for emotional integration did little in practice, to inject a sense much less a way, of achieving unity. Gramdan which constituted a proven foundation for both emotional and material integration continued to be the affair of a small band of dedicated men and women,—only a few thousands in a country of 430 millions—instead of becoming a national programme.

Peace Brigade's Potentialities

While a world Peace Brigade has come into being the potentialities of Shanti Sena (Peace Brigade) are yet to be explored on the national plane. Some scattered and limited experiments *on the spot* have borne out that Shanti Sainiks or soldiers of peace can ultimately replace the police and constabulary—which are generally more provocative than preventive—so far as the maintenance of internal law and order is concerned. Without the requisite moral sanction that flows from selfless service of the locality, of the people at large, programmes of action operated by unknown, unfriendly faces on a landless or rowdy elements are bound to be abortive or only very temporarily effective. A person or persons noted for service can exercise a natural command, born of love and affection, on the local people and is a fit, instrument to deal with frayed tempers by a moral technique. So, in the various directions that one may throw our searchlight, one's discerning mind cannot but be impressed by the unique achievement,—in terms of material gain, but much more in terms of regaining the permanent values that sustain human life and society,—of the Bhoodan Movement. ●

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CHAPTER VI

(*Vedanta In Practice*)

FROM POCHAMPALLI TO KAMARPUKUR

An unceasing quest from individual to universal, from being to Supreme Being, from personal to impersonal is what characterizes the Vedanta. The edifice of this living philosophy rests on the assumption of indivisibility of the universe, of the essential unity that holds all men of the world, nay all creations, together.

And what is Sarvodaya ? 'Sarvodaya' means the rise of all, or universal development : all-round development of individual and the universe. And the concept of an indivisible world leads to the conclusion that the rise of an individual is as much the rise of the universe ; growth of a part, from an integral stand-point, subserves the growth of the whole. It is this faith in the spiritual oneness of the world that sustains Sarvodaya. Sarvodaya Movement is nothing else or nothing less than the realization of this fundamental unity.

The common ground between Vedanta and Sarvodaya, on the philosophical plane, is thus obvious. In concrete terms, Sarvodaya is a gallant extension of

Vedanta which attained a unique practicable exposition in the merger of two majestic streams, viz : Shri Ramakrishna and Swami Vivekananda at Dakshineswar on the bank of the sacred Bhagirathi.

Practical Vedanta pinpointed the illusion that surrounded the material world in its diverse character, and established how by a universal approach man could dispel this illusion and rise above it even in the whirlpool of matters. Sarvodaya is a spirited effort to realize this way of right living, by divorcing the egoist first person like 'I', and 'mine' and substituting therefor the second person such as 'you' and 'yours'. Insistence on the person 'second to me', i.e., on the neighbours, initiates as a logical process, a circle of shared or collective living.

In his soulful homage to Shri Ramakrishna, who revolutionized the concept of religion by a synthetic universal approach, Mahatma Gandhi observed :

'The story of Ramakrishna Paramhansa is a story of *religion in practice*. His life enables us to see God face to face. No one can read his life without being convinced that God alone is real and that all else is illusion. Ramakrishna is a living embodiment of Godliness. His sayings are not those of a mere learned man, but they are pages from the Book of Life. They are revelations from his own experi-

ence. They, therefore, leave on the reader an impression which he cannot resist. In this age of scepticism, Ramakrishna presents an example of a bright and living faith which gives solace to thousands of men and women who would otherwise have remained without spiritual light.'

It was this spiritual light which illumined the obsessed, yet inquisitive and restless, mind of Narendranath, later acknowledged as the world-shaking Sannyasi—Swami Vivekananda. It was this illumination again, which sparked the mind of the Mahatma with the brilliant concept of Sarvodaya and for setting himself at once to its application.

Blessed Narendranath attained to Samadhi or spiritual ecstasy by the divine way of his Master; this was a sublime experience that he sought to perpetuate for personal bliss and salvation. This, he realized was the way of complete detachment from worldly affairs and immersion in the supreme. Shri Ramakrishna was visibly distressed by this attitude of his disciple and pointed out to him that he was not meant for harbouring individualism, his mission consisted in *service to mankind*. And the disciple descended to plunge himself into the service of the suffering. Practised religiosity, decreed by his Master, was the metal that the Swamiji was made of and this religion which

He defined as 'the manifestation of divinity already in man' constituted the core of his quest for the man-God (Nara-Narayan) in universal service and the creation of a monastic organization, later known all over the world as Ramakrishna Mission.

Mark the word *Service*. Mere mention of the word charity or mercy would wound the feelings of Shri Ramakrishna. Addressing Narendranath and some other disciples, Shri Ramakrishna said, "They talk of mercy to the creatures! How audacious it is to think of showing mercy on the *Jiva* who is none other than *Shiva*! One has to regard the creature as God Himself and proceed to serve it with a devout heart instead of taking up the pose of doling out mercy."

Is it not a sacrilege to take a higher stand, to look upon one's own self, in a fit of ego no doubt, as sanctimonious and stretch out a *helping* hand, in condescension, to the suffering? Such merciful mood disgraces the Divinity Himself in whose satisfaction the mercy is supposed to have been doled out.

So, the Swamiji emphatically declared, "All these are One manifested in different forms. To realize this unity is the aim and end of all meditation." And then, in a commanding voice he extolled, "Where should you go to seek for God? Are not all the poor, the misera-

ble, the weak, Gods? Why not worship them first? God is here before you in various forms." Swamiji further stressed, '*he who loves his creatures serves God.*' He ridiculed the disposition of 'digging a well on the shores of the Ganges', and exhorted, 'Let these people be your God; think of them, work for them, pray for them incessantly, the Lord will show you the way.'

Like a firebrand Vedantist, the Swamiji roared, "Him I call a Mahatma (high-souled) whose heart bleeds for the poor, otherwise he is a Duratma (wicked-souled.)"

And a Mahatma of Swamiji's dimension did, indeed, reveal in M. K. Gandhi. The same intensity of communion with God and identification with the downtrodden made him the 'father' of the great Indian nation and after his sudden laying down of the mortal frame appeared in a wider context and in firm, stirring steps, yet another highsouled person, Acharya Vinoba Bhave, with precisely the same conviction and mission! The stake of a new-born democracy engrossed in a thousand and one paralysing problems was averted with the emergence of a mighty soul in a frail body.

As Gandhiji himself stated, the reading of John Ruskin's 'Unto This Last' brought about an instantaneous revolution in his thought and induced him to put into immediate practice the principle that this out-

standing work upheld. Gandhiji paraphrased the book in Gujarati under style "Sarvodaya". While 'Unto This Last' would have literally meant 'Antyodaya', *the rise of the last man*, Bapu preferred a positive title, obviously visualizing a society of universal well-being which was a logical sequence to the rise of the last man in the society. The 'talisman' that Gandhiji gave to his followers also unmistakably points out that nearest to his heart and attention was the question of alleviating the miseries of the common man. 'I will give you a talisman', he said. 'Whenever you are in doubt or when the self becomes too much with you, apply the following test. Recall the face of the poorest and weakest man whom you may have seen, and ask yourself, if the step you contemplate is going to be of any use to *him*. Will he gain anything by it? Will it restore him to a control over his own life and destiny? In other words, will it lead to Swaraj for the hungry and starving millions? Then you will find your doubt and your self melting away.' So, that was the criterion of all Gandhian programmes. And what is Vinobaji's approach and mission?

During the last twelve years of Bhoodan Yajna, Vinobaji has time and gain pointed out that Bhoodan was no charity, from the 'haves' to the 'have-nots'. It was a principle that applied equally to the donor and the donee, to the giver and the recipient. Bhoodan

which is a means to Sarvodaya, upholds the way of right living, of uniting hearts in a world that is fast disintegrating under the impact of a soul-killing materialist civilization. The whole premises of Sarvodaya also built up on the cardinal principle that man could not grow alone and could not live by bread alone.

In a foreword to 'The Essence of Quran' (this unique compilation by Vinobaji is also another redeeming evidence of his universal outlook), Vinobaji writes :

"For years I have been continuously engaged in Padayatra (pilgrimage on foot) in the cause of Bhoodan which too, has, as its *sole purpose*, the *union of hearts*." "As a matter of fact", Vinobaji emphasizes, "all my activities throughout my life have been motivated by this *single objective of uniting hearts*."

It was this motive-power that drove him down to Telengana which experienced the horror of a holocaust. Frustrated landless peasants misguided by ambitious politicians took recourse to violence and killed thousands of adversaries. And the reprisal by the Administration added to the mounting death-roll. His heart bled at the suffering of men at the hands of fellowmen, he rushed and hazarded his appearance at the scene where bodies had piled up, reminding the country of Gandhiji's historic peace mission to riot-

torn Noakhali, now in East Pakistan. By the spell of this divine heart, man was restored, as if magically, to his senses, and unity once again established.

But no discerning eye could miss that Telengana was the signal to smouldering discontent. The disease was rooted, as Vinobaji knew, to the wanton discrimination and accumulated injustice, the denial of equal rights that accrued from the accepted principle of an essential unity.

The Pochampalli, incident, which later turned into a world-stirring event promising to revolutionize and harmonize the whole course of human history, was a significant pointer to this deepseated discord and to a solvent of this discord hitherto unknown. The 'saint of Pavnar' in whom the suffering folk had already discovered a living image of Mahatma Gandhi, was virtually besieged by 'Harijans' (meaning 'Gods' Men', coined by Gandhiji), who were treated like untouchables (what a curse to Hindu civilization!). They were hewers of wood and drawers of water. The problem there as in most villages, was the maldistribution of land. They toiled from dawn to dusk in the lands of the fortunate few while themselves leading a miserable life of semistarvation. Although in dire distress, they entreated Vinobaji for some 80 acres of land,—and *not charity*. Dead silence reigned in the meeting, when Vinobaji, turning to his audience, asked: "Is there

anyone here who will give me land for these landless Harijans?"

"Yes, I will", stepped forward a man, blessed Ramachandra Reddy, the first donor in the Bhoodan Movement—and offered 100 acres, —20 acres more than what was wanted! What happened was no less dynamic than a miracle and this presented Vinoba with a solution of the land problem, which held back the advance, material and spiritual, of not only India but most other countries of Asia and Africa. The vision of a new society gripped Vinobaji's mind so much so that he could not have a wink of sleep that night.

Here was an incident which again brought in bold relief how powerless is man's ego, before the divine consciousness of unity or his oneness with the rest of the universe; how a mind, ordinarily condemned as narrow, can respond magnificently to the spirit. Ramchandra Reddy and the Harijans of Pochampalli acted as the two geometrical points of a straight line which leads *jivatma* to *paramatma*, individual to universal, and that, be it noted again, in a process of service, *not charity*.

His unique mission, which aimed at infusing in the body-politic the sustaining values of fellow-feeling and shared living, began, therefore, with Bhoodan, or land to the landless. And Bhoodan or individual

landgifts developed, in the inevitable divine process of fulness, to whole gifts or Gramdan. In Gramdan the individual became universal or collective, *collective Samadhi*, as Vinobaji calls it.

Unto this world, God sent men as equals under the same undivided roof of the blue sky, for a collective headway, but men, in their craze for temporal pleasure and transient possession, divided and disgraced themselves. There are a thousand times more stone walls and iron bars than we ostensibly notice in the present-day world !

Shri Ramakrishna's Vedantist outlook rang the death-knell of disunited, charitable living. Swami Vivekananda, the *Viswamanav*—a universal man—nailed the coffin with his giant fist, Mahatma Gandhi reached the message to the farthest doors to mobilize the teeming millions for the funeral and Acharaya Vinoba Bhave actually engaged himself in the task while lighting up an alternative for the rotten socio-economic structure.

"The sages of the past gave up the sense of the 'I' and the 'mine', Vinobaji pointed out, "the Vedanta taught that, nothing—neither this house, nor this field, nor even this body—was mine ; likewise when we rise to the level of Vijnana (science) we should say that this house, this property, all these are *ours*."

The challenging exponent and architect of a society on the foundation of GRAMDAN (village where land has been voluntarily socialised), practical Vedanta assumed incredible proportions. Gramdan which, significantly, Vinobaji often characterizes as *collective samadhi*, is essentially a spiritual phenomenon at the initial stage, when landholders renounce ownership in deference to the call of the Spirit. They accept the principle of freedom of personal attachment and practise collective enjoyment as the first essential step to complete renunciation. An act of emotion, of a spark of self-knowledge, Gramdan declaration has, therefore, to be vigorously pursued by programmes of scientific development in order that the desired synthesis of science and spirituality could become a reality from grassroots.

Live and Let Live

Unlike the practice, no doubt commendable in itself, of dedicated souls putting in their selfless services for the large body of *recipients* in the society, Gramdan has initiated the principle of live and let live, of *universal development by universal service*, without which spirit the recipients may tend, and they do tend, to perpetuate the state of dependence instead of flowering their own personality, in relation to their neighbours. In other words, the revolutionary content of Vedanta has

immensely enriched with the emergence of Gram-dan.

Collective Samadhi

“What I want is that mankind should come to experience a *collective samadhi*. This is the seemingly unattainable ideal that the quest for self knowledge should place before itself,” Vinobaji said, while pointing out, “in Bengal at the place where Ramakrishna Paramahansa had attained to samadhi (at Vishnupur, in the district of Bankura, which Vinobaji visited in January, 1955—writer)”. I had said, “You ought to experience in the collective form the same samadhi which in its individual form Ramakrishna Paramahansa had realized. An out and out unattainable ideal. But I am unable to express how much inspiration I derive from such an unattainable ideal. This aspiration fills me the very marrows”.

Full twelve years (a *yuga*, which according to time-honoured belief, indicates the end of an era and the ushering of a new one) have elapsed since the Bhagirath of the twentieth century invoked the motherly flow of the Ganges to the parching earth. Besides Gram-dan, which is a highly scientific development, providing the requisite dynamics to the concept of a socialist economy, the Movement has registered notable strides in the form of Shanti Sena (peace army), Sarvodaya

Patra (an earthen pot in which is daily poured a handful of corn or a naya paise by the youngest child of a household thus identifying the householder with the greater world) and these also breathe of the same spirit.

At Kamarpukur

On 18th April, 1963, which marked the completion of a *yuga* of the Bhoodan Yajna, Vinobaji got in touch with the holy Kamarpukur village, the birthplace of Sri Ramakrishna who installed at the ordinary household the Vedanta of inaccessible forests. Vinobaji claimed Kamarpukur as ‘the land of my father’, while admitting, in his characteristic humility, “how difficult it is to be a son”.

“Rama worked with the bow and arrow, Krishna won the world with flute, Gotama by Dhyana yoga and Ramakrishna through *tyaga* (renunciation)”, Vinobaji observed at Kamarpukur while declaring that that day marked the beginning of his *tyaga yatra* (pilgrimage of renunciation).

Man is born in renunciation and dies in renunciation; not even a loin cloth he can carry on his waist. And birth and death being the two entrances to life, which is eternal, the limited span spent in between should conform to the truth, which was renunciation. But to outright reject the world as *maya* (myth) would

be too frightening a suggestion to the ordinary men and women. Hence the unique lesson of Sri Ramakrishna to the householders to live like the 'pankal fish', a kind of fish that lives in mud but does not get stuck in the mud due to its lubricating exterior. A detached or disinterested way of living gives to the human beings the same liberating quality which is at once elevating. Swamiji's immortal call also would come to mind in this connection : "Like the silkworm you have built a cocoon around yourself. To save you cut your own cocoon and come out as the beautiful butterfly, as the free soul", he said.

Emotional Integration

Since the commencement of the third round of his *padayatra* in the state, Vinobaji has often asserted himself in terms of a spiritual revolution in West Bengal. Emotion is a trait of Bengali character, as the Sarvodaya leader himself has noted, and Bengal's soil is, therefore, ideally suited for such transformation of values that sustain the society.

Gramdan is initially an emotional act, as we have already pointed out, so it is not the End, but the beginning of the End. Putting it in an interesting perspective, Vinobaji said, "They ask : have the villagers of Gramdan given up all attachment ? I say, they have brought about Gramdan, which means they have staged a drama.

Science deems this drama essential. Science again will turn this stage-acting into a reality". Gramdan is the outcome of an emotional integration. All integrations have, in fact, a necessary element of drama in them. The essence of the matter is that without an integrated ground no scientific development is feasible. Similarly no integration is worthwhile unless followed by the dynamic accompaniment of science.

May the day on which the 'walking saint' established physically his spiritual communion with the embodiment of the Vedanta at Dakshineswar be the harbinger of a new era for Bengal, for the rest of India and the whole world by forging a synthesis of Vedanta and Sarvodaya on a firmer basis. ●

CHAPTER VII

VINOBA ON BENGAL

Bengal has presented a fascinating picture to Acharya Vinoba Bhave since his boyhood. And the love has ever grown, so much so that today at the very mention of Bengal's saints and savants, Vinoba's eyes become moist.

Some of our leading litterateurs would, I believe, readily remember the pathos which, on the occasion of Vinobaji's address to them at Abhoy Ashram, Balaram-pore, in the district of Midnapore, in the course of his first *Padayatra* in 1955, surcharged the meeting place. The Acharya's voice was choked and tears rolled down soaking the hearts of his listeners. "From Bapu" he said, "I have obtained the peace of the Himalayas and the revolutionary fervour of Bengal. I have dedicated my life to the cause of peaceful revolution. When in 1916 I left home, a two-fold attraction was enchanting me : one was the Himalayas for the quest of the Brahma (God) and the other was Bengal's revolutionaries, out of an inspiration for freedom. Mid-way I was held up in Kashi. From there I went to Bapu at Sabarmati Ashram. At the feet of Bapu I achieved a synthesis of peace and revolution."

Why is it that Bengal has struck the inmost chord of Vinoba's soul ? The blood of revolutionary Maharashtra flows through his veins, and his mind and soul drew unremittingly from Bengal's spiritual tradition, the first indelible lesson of spirituality having been imprinted on his impressionable mind by his mother. It was, therefore, natural that the identical life of revolutionary sacrifice and spiritual efflorescence, which characterized Bengal through the ages, should prove irresistible to Vinoba. Revolution and renunciation are, in essence, the two sides of the same coin. Despite the obvious differences that approach, both are paths of selfless sacrifices.

There was this two-fold achievement of Bengal, fire-brand revolution and deliberate renunciation or spiritualism, which fascinated Vinoba ; and in later years his fascination seems to have been surrounded hundred per cent by Bengal's spiritualism of which the latest votaries were Ramakrishna and Vivekananda. Right in the line of his Master—Mahatma Gandhi—Vinoba's soul is sustained by Ramakrishna and his body by Vivekananda. Vinobaji's boundless reverence for these two is borne out by numerous observations that the Bhoooodan leader made in his speeches in Bengal in 1955 and subsequently at other places.

In 1952 a Sarvodaya Sammelan was held at Hatuganj (Shri Charu Chandra Bhandari's Ashram), Dia-

mond Harbour, which, for all practical purposes, marked the beginning of the Bhoodan movement in Bengal. Inspired by Vinobaji Shri Bhandari quit party politics and dedicated himself to the cause of Bhoodan. The Hatuganj Conference was indeed a land-mark in Bengal's enlightened activity when this truncated and problem-ridden State had lapsed into despair and desperation. In the course of a message to this Conference Vinobaji observed :

"Bengal has sacrifice and patriotism ; she also possesses enough strength ; but today our country is ransacked by partisan activities. It is due to her sweeping emotion that Bengal suffers from too much of them. All should forget this and commit to Sarvodaya. We may not mark the label pasted on one's forehead, but may have an insight into the Omniscient existing in one's heart. Let us shun all senses of egotism and pride and put our shoulders together in the service of *Daridra-Narayan* (God in the poor). It is only then that there will be the advent in Bengal of the power of universal good. Bengal where the tenets of Sankhya, Buddha, Shakti and Vaishnava spread, where the all-embracing Visva-Bharati has been founded, could set an example before the rest of India by adopting this work. It was a savant of Bengal who coined the word *Daridra-Narayan*, and it is to instal the *Daridra-Narayan* in everybody's heart that God has

bestowed on us the duty of Bhoodan-Yajna. May we apply our full strength to its successful culmination."

The 6th Sarvodaya Sammelan was held in Bodh Gaya in April 1954. Speaking to the conference of Bengal's workers there on this occasion Vinobaji said :

"Bengal is a very powerful province. She has sacrifice and enterprise. In enterprising activity Bengal has no match in India. She is, nevertheless, a land of sorrows. Her present-day conditions create anxiety. To remove the political filth and squabbles that beset Bengal today is the primary duty of Bengal's workers. It must not be allowed to happen that Bengal is torn asunder by political bickerings. Bengal has enough of sorrows but little of governmental power. There is paucity of land. Also there is lack of business skill in the Bengalees.

"There is, however, universal hankering for securing even this limited ruling power. We (the Bhoodan workers) must beware of this lure the involvement in which will reduce us to a mere branch of it (power politics). Our attitude to election, therefore, should be one, of aversion. That in itself will be the source of political strength. This is my special message to the workers of Bengal."

Vinobaji delves deeper than usual, whenever it is the case of Bengal. 'Of Bengal I beg, not land but

love,' he said in 1955, in 1961 and again the other day at Radhikapore in West Dinajpore, soon after the commencement of his third *Padayatra* in the State on September 21. He detests the idea of land-gift if it is devoid of love. In course of one of his speeches in 1955 Vinobaji underlined the original thoughts that emerged from Bengal. The Acharya said :

"I value not so much the land that is given to me but love and affection with which it is donated. Right thought has always been in this country the sheet-anchor of our faith. Once a thought pervades society, the latter is transformed of its own accord. That is why in our ancient history literature began with *Brahma Vidya* or divine knowledge. Then followed the evolution of India's social science. This is also found in modern Indian history. You know that of all parts of India, the British first occupied Bengal. In other countries alien domination has been followed either by passive submission of the people or by an armed revolt. But here they did neither. Then what did the great souls of Bengal do ? They took to purification of thought and religion. Raja Ram Mohan Roy taught us that Swaraj would follow religious and social reform. I know of no other country where people took to social reform after foreign control. The role of right thought in the growth of our country cannot be too much stressed."

"Once Bengal realises the idea that Bhoodan-Yajna represents, she will offer landgifts in a million hands. A current of renunciation and gift will then flow ceaselessly from her heart,"—this is Vinoba's conviction. If Vinoba's longing was satiated by the synthesis of Himalayan peace and Bengal's fiery urge for freedom that Gandhiji's personality provided him with, it is the same synthesis wherein lies the remedy for the deep-seated ills which have been paralysing the life of Bengal. 'A synthesis of *Shakti* (strength) and *Bhakti* (devotion or godliness) constituted the main plank on which Bengal could rebuild herself' this was the theme of many of his prayer speeches in North Bengal in February 1961.

Vinobaji lays bare his heart in grateful acknowledgment of what he has gained from Bengal. Not only his own but the rest of India's attention also he directs again and again to Bengal. To Chief Minister Shri P. C. Sen, Vinobaji reiterated on the 21st September at Radhikapur his indebtedness to Bengal's saints and savnats and conveyed his readiness to footmarch in West Bengal for years, if necessary, 'in redemption of the debt that the rest of India owes to Bengal'.

CHAPTER VIII
FREEDOM FROM HUNGER : FREEDOM
FOR ALL

Hunger haunts today nearly one half of the world population which now stands at about 3,000,000,000. Either they do not get enough to eat or eat the non-eatables,—with what consequence nobody need be told, while there is a suicidal arms race involving a total annual expenditure of 100,000 million dollars in which the share of the under-developed countries is about 5,000 million dollars. Human skeletons, driven out of their village homes by scarcity of food and desperately searching 'food' on the pavements or in the dustbins, are no rare sights in a city like Calcutta. Go to Sealdah in the same city, one of the busiest railway stations, and you will come to know how hundreds of displaced families, battling with hunger, have dwelt in the open or in so-called hutments during the last one decade of gruelling summer, drowning rains and deadening winter. And this is a station which provides the everyday doorstep, of no less than a lakh educated, semi-educated or 'going-

to-be-educated' men and women to one of the greatest centres of modern civilization. Such instances can be easily multiplied.

Conditions will appear far more awful, appalling and dreadful if we spotlight on the child-victims of hunger or under-nourishment. With children lies the kingdom of God : and what hunger is doing to this divine posterity ! According to a disclosure made by a UNICEF spokesman in 1962 :

'in the last twelve years well over a thousand million babies have been born in the world, of which between 150 and 200 million died before reaching their first birthday. Of the survivors between 600 and 650 million were exposed to hunger and to diseases such as malaria, Yaws, trachoma, tuberculosis, leprosy, threatening premature death, disfiguration, blindness or debility. Of the original thousand million babies born during the last twelve years only something between 150 and 250 million have received a fair start in life to fit them as future citizens of their countries and the world.'

In the same *human family*, while in the U. K., a child's life expectancy is 70 years, in India it is only 32.

And these are the conditions obtaining in the mid-twentieth century world when the marvels of science

have made it possible for man to undertake journeys into the outer space, but alas, he does not know how to travel on good earth with his fellow beings ! What kind of conquest is it ?

Freedom From Hunger campaign which Food and Agriculture Organisation launched on July 1, 1960, and has since been pursued by national programmes seeks to awaken the people, all over the world, to their *first duty* to feed their hungry, fellow-brethren, in the neighbourhood or in the distant overseas. The campaign which is educative to pool charities in different forms. As a compassionate effort, it is, therefore, a commendable programme, so far as it goes.

It need not be pointed out, however, that the disease is deep-rooted and to lift up all men of the world to equal dignity we must axe at the root of poverty and hunger. Without prejudicing or undertoning the surface-palliatives, a revolutionary programme has to be devised on the international plane so that the danger of exploitation, of yawning gaps between members of the *same family* may be weeded out once and for all. Gramdan Movement in India provides the key to such a basic solution.

The industrial revolution of the nineteenth century brought about tremendous wealth for one part of

the world and grinding pauperization for the other part. The West registered a technological advance of huge magnitude and her devouring factory economy was fed by raw materials exploited from the East which was and is still principally a producer of raw materials. Thus two water-tight economics, one out-and-out industrial and another agricultural, were created to the wanton imbalance in living conditions between man and man. Countries like the U. K. and America rolled in affluence and luxuries while poverty and pestilence perpetuated in countries like India. The advance of technological devices bade good-bye to human relationships and wisdom and an era of arms race was in the offing.

Injustices or indignities thus heaped on the teeming millions gave rise to two reactions : either they were seized with fear, lost all self-confidence and initiative, or surrendered to violent passions. The loss to civilization in either case was colossal. Between fear and poverty, it is not easy to assess which is a greater evil.

A programme of feeding the hungry should, therefore, insure that human dignities which have palpably lowered due to a pernicious socio-economic system and a dole-giving machinery in many parts of the world, are lifted.

The problem of hunger is inherent in private ownership of land that provides food. This explains the cruel paradox that although the available resources of the world can feed all men, hunger stalks one-half of the world. Distributed on equity or equitability, these resources could wipe out poverty, therewith disallowing affluence or concentration of wealth in the hands of a few. Increase of production, as such, is therefore a poor or no solves ; it must necessarily be accompanied with equitable distribution. Even more than ushering in an era of prosperity, it is the speedy *distribution of poverty*, yes, distribution of the available resources which are admittedly poor, which warrants our immediate attention. Even the Five Year Plans of India, than which perhaps no other country knows where the shoe pinches, have failed to recognise this urgency and relegated the issue of 'reducing inequalities' and of 'a more even distribution of economic power' to the fifth place in their statement of aims. The damping result will be obvious from studies revealed by the Planning Commission itself.

Gramdan (communal ownership of land) by initiating a process of voluntary renunciation of private ownership of land, vesting of such ownership in a representative village council and cooperatives en-

terprises of equals provides the necessary dynamics for a revolutionary social change while preventing both the reactions mentioned above. Freedom From Hunger campaign must needs be extended to this deeper significance in order that it is reduced to a mechanical international machinery for giving out doles. Happily, a good beginning has been made, with funds raised by such campaigns, in a number of villages toned up with Gramdan dynamics. Acharya Vinoba Bhave the moving spirit behind the Bhoodan-Gramdan movement has come to symbolize the challenging mission of the emerging new world which is building up on the principles of self-denial and universal development that Gramdan represents.

A land of villages as it is, it was ideally suited to the genius and objective condition of the country that Vinobaji adopted *Bhoodan* (individual gifts of land) and *Gramdan* (whole village gift) as the medium of his unique movement. In other countries, different mediums may have to be used, the fundamental guiding principles, however, remaining the same. Cannot the UNO and more particularly the FAO which has built up this campaign, bestow some serious thought on such projects in each of her member-countries ?

Meanwhile so far as the eradication of hunger is concerned, we would suggest some radical measures :

(1) An International Council should be set up and exercised on all production and distribution of food, food being considered a vital material transcending national geography or economy :

(2) International Movements of foodstuffs should be free from all restrictive rules and customs.

(3) International Granaries or store-houses should be built up in countries deficit in food, so that food could be rushed to the hungry ;

(4) Money-exchange in food transactions of all kinds should be abolished.

Shri B. R. Sen, FAO'S Director-General observed that "One man's hunger and want is everyman's hunger and want. One man's freedom from hunger and want is neither a true nor a secure freedom until all men are free from hunger and want." Nothing short of a programme based on a universal conviction, will be fit enough to deliver the goods to all men of the world.

सर्व सेवा संघ पुस्तकालय

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